eg update

送信者: Ian Bremmer 受信日時: 2026-10-26 20:52

【メール原文】

dear hondo-san, what comes after the g-zero? troubles in france. and quick thoughts on messing with the us midterms and the next iran war steps. after the g-zero it's

||||||||||||||||||||||||||||||||||||||||

dear hondo-san,

what comes after the g-zero? troubles in france. and quick thoughts on messing with the us midterms and the next iran war steps.

after the g-zero

it's been 15 years now since i started writing about the g-zero world, where the united states no longer provides global leadership and no other country or group of countries is willing or able to replace it. but the g-zero is necessarily an unstable environment, a power vacuum that leads to weaker alliances and institutions, breeding uncertainty and resulting in instability. the longer the g-zero persists, the more costly the resulting conflicts.

as the reality of the g-zero (and, the other side of this coin, the permanence of the destruction of the old, united states-led global order) becomes more apparent, we are starting to see a number of post-g-zero alternatives receiving attention. spoiler: i'm not (yet) convinced by any of them. but like anticipating the g-zero well before our geopolitical recession arrived, it's best to think through the possibilities and implications early.

1 - us v. china: a new cold war

this is the easiest post-g-zero world to envision, because china is the only near-superpower peer to the united states. china's economy is smaller, but its industrial policy is more consolidated and strategic (not to mention consistent over time), and its trade relations globally more influential. china now stands as a technological competitor with the united states, with no other country close. china's diplomatic capabilities are more limited (though those of the united states have atrophied, particularly over the second trump term); with the big gaps being china's lack of global military reach and competitive reserve currency. unless you consider europe a unified "pole" (and that's likely to remain far from the case), an objective assessment of global power by 2035 looks more like a world with two superpowers.

those two superpowers are more likely to be in conflict than harmony. president trump's orientation toward authoritarian leaders (given their personal power and the absence of domestic checks and balances on their decision-making) has led to a rapprochement between the two countries this year, but the longer-term orientation is a decoupling—an effort by both sides to "win" the global ai race rather than cooperate; alongside an expansion of self-reliance in strategic sectors considered important for national security; while the political and economic systems of the two countries remain fundamentally unaligned.

but it's hard to see that evolving into a full-blown cold war. the united states is more interested in undoing its role in the old global order than competing with the chinese over continuing to lead it. failed wars and fiscal constraints will limit american defense spending and commitments over the coming

decade; political mistrust will force leaders to prioritize domestic agendas and investment; and neither democrats nor republicans will be interested in a return to driving globalization and a free trade agenda. china is more focused on a robust "go out" strategy, but outside of china's backyard, that's expressed principally through commercial impulses where chinese power is dominant; while american leverage remains more on security—even in latin america—which mostly doesn't directly threaten chinese influence.

further, to fight a cold war, other countries have to be interested in (or compelled into) choosing between one or another "bloc." that's likely to remain far from the case. european growing mistrust of the united states has led to hedging behavior...but not sudden trust of the chinese. indeed, if anything worries about chinese industrial policy have created a european policy that's more hostile toward chinese state economic policy. japan, south korea, and australia remain much more committed to us collective security agreements, even as they erode in conviction, but with only limited hedging away from chinese economic exposure. and while china is increasingly likely to dominate the global export of ai models, the united states and allies (including taiwan, which remains unlikely to face outright invasion because of the extraordinary risks involved for beijing) will continue to dominate semiconductors. add to that the us bet on expanded carbon-based energy exports while china becomes the first global electrostate...and the coming decade makes access to both essential for most of the world's "middle powers." that's nearly the opposite of a cold war.

2 - a tripolar world: the united states, china, plus a growing middle power alignment

absent a second global cold war, is there space for a third, middle power bloc to emerge? a persistent g-zero world creates a growing necessity of hedging policies, in turn making middle power coordination more compelling. after all, for most countries individual negotiating leverage is limited—even when able to effectively balance between competing superpower suitors. a coordinated strategy—in protecting/reforming the existing multilateral architecture, building new international institutions, and direct bilateral negotiations with the americans and chinese—would be the most effective way to build outcomes more favorable to middle powers. can the "variable geometry" approach of canada pm mark carney (individual coalitions of the willing depending on the issue) eventually develop into a more aligned third power?

it's hard to imagine. the biggest challenge is europe, where you might think alignment would be easier. after all, the geopolitics for the europeans have become particularly problematic: 1) the united states, europe's core ally, is becoming more unilateral/less reliable; 2) russia is directly escalating its war inside (and increasingly across) europe; and 3) china is increasingly outcompeting europe in economic areas of core competence. all of which helps explain why the canadians, the brits, and others are more interested in increasing their countries' strategic cooperation and alignment with the european union. but europe's 27 member states are poorly aligned on the prioritization and relative urgency of these challenges, with some oriented toward individual policy defection. and that's only likely to become more challenging, with political momentum inside many european countries heading toward euroskepticism and the decentralization of power, particularly in france where marine le pen and her national rally party are now looking more likely than not to win the presidency next year.

absent a consolidated europe, there's plenty of room for expanded coalition building on areas of alignment (a critical minerals cartel among non-china/us producers and processors, for example; a new advanced industrial development bank and related initiatives; and coordinated tech/ai regulation to defend data sovereignty, civil society and the like). a rising india will be particularly influential on these fronts, especially given a strong and persistent strategic unwillingness to align too closely with either the

americans or chinese. but that's very different from an emergent third pole, which is hard to imagine in the next decade.

3 - spheres of influence: decentralization of geopolitics into regions

if there's no cold war and no emergent middle power grouping, while the united states is more focused on domestic politics and china only able to project military might regionally, could the post-g-zero world slip into a more decentralized order? could regions each become dominated by the most powerful actors in the neighborhood?

that's consistent with the recent "donroe doctrine," president trump's view that the united states should exert sovereignty over the western hemisphere. america's military success in venezuela, with a new/old regime in caracas resetting its economic relations to one dominated by washington, is the most obvious example of this; the united states changing the rule set over panama (given its small size and strategic/national security importance) is a second. it's easy to see analogies with china's effective control over cambodia and laos in asia, with more countries over time aligning in similar fashion as china's military capabilities and assertiveness in asia (and especially across the south china sea) increase.

and yet for most of the western hemisphere, us military preeminence will continue to coexist with chinese commercial preeminence; excepting in a few states where us military engagement truly determines outcomes (cuba could well become another), that's unlikely to change. similarly, across asia the most important economies will remain capable of maintaining their security ties with the americans—in part through greater burden sharing and self-reliance—while avoiding being dominated by china. that's certainly true of japan, south korea, and australia; while india is becoming sufficiently economically powerful and diplomatically respected to become a competitor with china for influence in much of asia.

where the sphere of influence argument appears strongest is the middle east. there, the likely retreat of the united states after yet another failed war creates a vacuum that will be filled by competing blocs: an islamic coalition, an abrahamic coalition, and an iran plus proxies bloc. the core question is whether that can lead to a stable broader architecture, or whether a regional conflagration is eventually risked. the latter represents a real danger, given long-term reduced oil revenues, supply chain and critical infrastructure vulnerability, comparatively weak political institutions, and the broader availability of inexpensive and destructive weapons.

3a - a new civilizationalism

a subset of a persistent g-zero leading to the decentralization of power into blocs is the prospect of a "clash of civilizations," as once popularized by samuel huntington, and now finding favor among nationalists in the united states and much of the advanced industrial world.

the trump national security strategy promoted us geopolitical dominion over its backyard, but a deeper read focused on the ideological alignment of shared ethnic and religious identity. failure on that front was presented as a bigger direct adversary to us security than russia or even china. this is becoming a principal political impulse on the american right—championed most clearly by vice president jd vance, xai owner elon musk along with much of the techno-right, and secretary of state marco rubio, as laid out in his speech in athens a few weeks ago.

by these measures, globalism is the enemy that needs to be combatted, yes economically but more principally in its attacks on national identity and control. the united states faces the danger of a deep

state controlled by an unaccountable professional class who values abstract causes and global integration over shared values, culture, race, and religion. europe risks extinction because national sovereignty is undermined by nationless bureaucrats in brussels.

this ideological perspective gaining purchase would lead the americans to more actively promote euroskeptic forces across the continent, while attempting to further the break between the united kingdom and the european union. algorithmic influence also would play a role in mobilizing ideologically aligned forces across countries (including among similarly minded political movements in the global south—as we presently see in argentina and south africa, for example), an important and growing impulse given us dominance of social media and the influence of ai agents across democracies.

more broadly, the embrace of civilizationalism would lead the united states to pursue closer engagement with russia, as well as greater tolerance for/sympathy to a russian slavic expansionism over ukraine and russian-populated regions of neighboring states (including eastern europe). advanced industrial asian states are more ethnically homogenous and wouldn't be as affected by the change: there's both more resonance with the idea and less controversy over the implications. a separate but analogous rise of the political salience of caste identifiers in india would sit well with conservative forces on the subcontinent. and insofar as it promotes separation of cultures over us exceptionalism, civilizationalism is an ideology more comfortable alongside a chinese communist party-run china (with little interest in the taiwan question). to be sure, we're far from this as a geopolitical organizing principle, but the reach of the political impulse is underappreciated.

4 - a technopolar world: ai supercompanies become dominant actors

if there's no new great power competition and regionalism proves too weak or uneven to determine governance and outcomes in most parts of the world, one other possibility where i've been increasingly focused of late is technopolarity. where the multinational corporations that direct and control artificial intelligence become dominant geopolitical actors in their own right.

artificial intelligence is certainly moving fast enough to challenge existing geopolitical norms and institutions. what has now already become the "too big to fail" component of the american market will also soon scale to the point that it's a competing force with national governments in determining economic, security, and societal outcomes. this is complicated by the fact that leaders inside the ai companies are the only ones who truly understand how much their activities are poised to change the existing power balance (and increasingly frequently, even those leaders are themselves caught unaware by ai capabilities). in that environment, by the time governments are prepared to act, it's plausibly too late.

and so, it's a safe bet that in five years' time, those that control artificial intelligence will become geopolitical actors vying for global influence and power. whether or not those actors will still be independent private sector corporations is another matter. for one thing, american hyperscalers today are not aligned (indeed, zuck, elon, dario, and sam personally dislike and are wildly distrustful of each other), making them more likely to blame each other when they face challenges from markets, governments or the public at large. that also makes it easier for some of them to "defect" from the market and align with the us military-industrial complex—which drives a lot of cash (especially important if ai turns out to be a bubble, as citadel ceo ken griffin is now credibly warning). and when half of the companies are saying there needs to be a "pacing" of the frontier because the science is moving too fast, and most of the american citizens are saying they don't trust the companies...it's clear we aren't going to have to wait long for policy-relevant backlash (including from third country

regulations that further fragment the previously global services). at a minimum, you'd expect that technopolarity in the west evolves into a hybrid model, where control and governance are shared between the tech companies and the government(s).

and critically, none of this applies to china, where the government (and, more essentially, the communist party) maintains control over the ai companies and how their technologies are deployed (not to mention the data and compute inputs they require, as well as the internet they function on). there's no near-term future where china devolves that authority to ai companies, no matter how fast they move—if anything, in china artificial intelligence is likely to consolidate more power in the hands of the state. to the extent that china is successful in advancing ai in service of projecting that power globally, it in turn is likely to make the united states more interested in emulating that model.

it's a profound geopolitical irony: not only did china's integration into a us-dominated order not lead to its alignment with western political and economic institutions, it's becoming more likely that the influence ultimately cuts in the other direction.

*

for now, none of these global orders appear likely or imminent. which gives rise to a final, nearer-term point: post-trump, we might see an evolution into...

5 - a zombie us-led order

could a more traditional us president assume office in 2029 (marco rubio, a moderated/post-trump implosion jd vance, or a centrist democrat like rahm emanuel, gavin newsom, or jb pritzker) and try to rebuild american alliances and reassert us international leadership the way that obama did post-george w bush? after all, the united states still has the most powerful global military in that environment, the global reserve currency, and economic and political institutions less opaque to advanced industrial democracies than those of china.

but such a dynamic would be limited by divided domestic politics in the united states that continue to support industrial policy rather than free trade; greater burden sharing rather than us-led collective security; and more limited and inconsistent willingness to promote democracy and rule of law. while american hard power would be increasingly constrained by the fiscal environment, hedging allies, and the influence of a rising china.

in short, it's the g-zero world with an ineffectual substitute teacher, who doesn't realize the students aren't particularly paying attention. whether or not that's the post-trump trajectory, it's the other potential orders we should be stress-testing for the longer term.

france - europe

i've been less concerned than most about the internal trends in europe. we heard all the euro panic about italy's giorgia meloni, the most durable leader italy's seen in generations, who proved much less a trump/elon wannabe than a pragmatic and politically savvy operator who became a core ally of eu president ursula von der leyen. hungary's viktor orban, the continent's biggest euroskeptic, was dramatically drummed out of office just a few months ago—replaced by a pro-rule of law, anti-corruption right-wing populist who wants to integrate hungary into the eurozone. speaking of which, the meteoric rise of reform in the united kingdom has been seriously dented by the incompetence and corruption of nigel farage, where a more politically capable, pro-eu labour pm andy burnham now has the political momentum. the rise of far-right populism in spain means a junior

coalition partner for a likely center-right government replacing pm sanchez in coming elections; if anything that probably makes the vox party more responsible. and while i'm not yet prepared to say that about the prospects of germany's alternative für deutschland, it's also true that germany's support for the eu and the eurozone isn't threatened by chancellor merz's implosion or replacement.

france is another matter. a few relevant points on the strategic implications of 2027: 1) marine le pen now looks like the odds-on favorite to win in next year's presidential election. she's sharply opposed to the draghi plan (which has been driving, however slowly, prospects for more european productivity and power on the global stage), a larger eu budget, and support for ukraine. 2) france is much larger than italy; so any bargaining that occurs after her election is more likely to see the europeans making concessions than le pen. also germany-france coordination has been essential to broader european industrial policy and defense coordination; that's implausible with le pen as president. 3) president trump would still be in office for another year and a half; suddenly emboldened by his most powerful new transatlantic ally, at the same time he's looking to normalize relations with russia...which would become a shared goal.

and then there's getting there. the french ten-year bond is presently trading at higher rates than greece; markets are appropriately concerned that france's fiscal imbalances are unsustainable and there's no political will to bring down social spending (among the highest in europe), increase taxation, or raise the retirement age. indeed, le pen promises to do none of those things...which might lead france to be punished the way liz truss was when she was prime minister...but le pen isn't (yet) in power, meaning macron is taking the brunt of the hits. meanwhile france faces social discontent across the country, with lots of violent riots—which further hurts the political establishment, while benefiting the far right and their calls for order and security.

lest you think it's the beginning of the end for the european union, le pen has tossed aside her calls for "frexit" because they were a political loser across the country. spending less and stopping further integration in its tracks is one thing; trying to unwind the european union is not in the cards (except gradually and by stealth). france isn't actually a large spender on ukraine—germany, the united kingdom, japan all contribute far more—so a decision to opt out wouldn't itself be existential for kyiv. however, in combination with le pen's opposition to the eu budget (where a further €100 billion in aid for ukraine is planned), it could be. le pen's anti-immigration policies are more aligned with the center right in europe today (and even some of the center left); dramatic reductions in migration over the past year show mostly that the politics haven't yet caught up with the policies. the real problem is not what le pen would do but what she would refuse to do or block. the challenge is that europe already faces too many geopolitical challenges and desperately needs more coordinated policies to grow and compete more effectively; that's absolutely not in the cards if france goes the way it's presently looking.

*

in the us midterms, president trump approved a lawsuit against the upcoming alaska ballot, if the democratic candidate wins. the justification is a second dan sullivan (no party affiliation) added to the ballot, alongside republican dan sullivan (note: is that two dans sullivan or two dan sullivans?); and so, if the republican loses by less than the vote total for the extra sullivan, it wouldn't be recognized. but the state court already allowed it, so this is highly unlikely to go anywhere.

yes, it shows trump has no interest in recognizing the outcomes of an election when he doesn't like them (hardly new on this front, but still noteworthy). but it's more relevant that it's a recognition of how badly things are going for the gop, and they don't have any good options...scrambling in a red state

shows how weak their estimates for the national outcome are. the department of justice will continue its poor track record with this one; a bigger question is how much the potential suit would succeed in sowing doubt about the result, and how much that would help with similar challenges in 2028...

and on iran, as we get closer to the midterms, more talk about a return to us military strikes soon after. there's us intelligence on advanced iranian planning to target americans in the region; more direct engagement between the united states and israel around a war plan; and a higher level of tanker attrition. on the latter, we've heard that the iranians have switched to targeting engine rooms rather than hulls, which take months to repair rather than a few weeks. at present, near-term tanker depletion rates (with some smaller companies within weeks of not being able to field tankers) are becoming a key reason, possibly the most important, driving considerations to engage in strikes.

*

lastly, in latin america and europe, some pro-democracy developments over the weekend, not without their complications... president lula in brazil came back to win unexpectedly over flávio bolsonaro in the second round of the election (who has not yet conceded after a controversial court decision to extend voting hours, but it's a large enough margin that it won't matter)—unwelcome news for the trump administration and markets; positive for those worried about a jair bolsonaro pardon and what that would mean for brazilian institutions. in venezuela opposition leader maría corina machado returned to the country after almost a year in exile, communicated in advance with the trump administration but with an election timeline still uncertain (and unlikely to be soon). meanwhile, in serbia, longtime leader aleksandar vučić and his party lost the parliamentary election after a two-year student movement against his government—with uncertainty over who will now become prime minister in this new era for serbia.

i'll be in paris, of all places, end of the week for an event and some meetings (and apparently some protests). shall try to avoid the latter. but never a calm time these days.

with best wishes,

ian

© 2026 Eurasia Group. All rights reserved. This material was produced by Eurasia Group for use by the recipient. This is intended as general background research and is not intended to constitute advice on any particular commercial investment or trade matter or issue and should not be relied upon for such purposes. It is not to be made available to any person other than the recipient. No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic or otherwise, without the prior consent of Eurasia Group.
X-HG-DocID cmvp6jib5jg3q07n1z1m2bm32

PDF | Opt Out | Customize Email Preferences